

property in the lower South, which Buchanan had not opposed. By this time, only two important military installations—Fort Sumter in Charleston, South Carolina, and Fort Pickens in Florida—remained in Federal hands. Lincoln wished to sustain the claims of the Federal government to sovereign authority in the seceded states, but he also did not want to trigger a shooting war that might drive the upper South into the Confederacy.

As Lincoln confronted the question of how to enforce the Federal government's claims to the two endangered Federal forts, the upper South continued to wrestle with secession. The state of Virginia, in particular, played a critical role in this debate, because of its large population, substantial economic resources, and its symbolic importance to the history of the republic. Upper South and border state legislators led last-ditch attempts at crafting another intersectional compromise to preserve the Union, as had been done in the past, but moderates faced the dual challenges of a president elected on a platform that would prohibit any extension of slavery and the physical fact of the lower South's secession and the divisions that it created. Meanwhile, as the politicians schemed and quarreled, the Federal military establishment found itself divided. Most U.S. Army officers came from West Point Military Academy, which ensured sectional balance, because appointments were allotted on the basis of congressional districts. Most, but not all, lower South officers immediately resigned their commissions to go off and fight for the Confederacy. In contrast, officers from the upper South found themselves as torn and conflicted as their states.

General in Chief of the Army, Winfield Scott—a grand old Virginian who had fought with distinction as a division commander in the War of 1812 with Britain, and had conquered Mexico City in 1846—advocated a cautious course of conciliation that found *de facto* support in Buchanan's policy of inaction.

In February 1861, Republicans in Congress helped pass a 13th amendment to the Constitution protecting slavery in the states where it already existed as a conciliatory gesture. It never received state approval.

11 The number of Confederate states at the end of May 1861, while 23 stayed in the Union.